

The Social Radars

S1: David Lieb, Creator of Google Photos

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Jessica Livingston: I'm Jessica Livingston, and Carolyn Levy and I are The Social Radars. In this podcast, we talk to some of the most successful founders in Silicon Valley about how they did it. Carolyn and I have been working together to help thousands of startups at Y Combinator for almost 20 years. Come be a fly on the wall as we talk to founders and learn their true stories.

Today we're talking to David Lieb, who I'm thrilled to say has recently joined Y Combinator as a visiting group partner. If any of you were around Silicon Valley in 2009, you might remember a cool new technology where you transferred your contact info from one person to another by literally bumping phones. Well, David was one of the founders of Bump Technologies. He'll share bumps, ups and downs as they went from business school side hustle to hot new iOS app to ultimately transforming into the wildly popular Google Photos. Enjoy.

So we're here with David Lieb. We're so excited to have you, David. I want you to tell me, because I was talking to Carolyn saying I remembered when we interviewed Bump back in, it would've been 2009. We were all so excited during the interview. You had great technology, but I think you might not have, you almost didn't do Y Combinator, right? What happened?

David Lieb: It was wild, we were total noobs. We didn't know anything. So we applied to YC. I think we heard about YC, because Jake and I, two of the three founders, we were former engineers but we had gone to business school, which we can talk about later. But we were reading TechCrunch, and TechCrunch was the hot thing back then. And we were like, "What is this thing called Y Combinator? Everybody keeps talking about it, maybe we should research that for our little project that we're working on." And turns out we knew one person who had done YC or maybe two people, Shiraj from... I knew Shiraj from college.

Jessica Livingston: From Princeton, right?

David Lieb: Yeah, from Princeton. And he had done it and he said great things, obviously. So we came for the interview and it was great. But afterwards, we were the hot startup. We had millions of users. All the VCs were trying to network with us, but we didn't know anything. We were just two or three kids. But Andy, our third co-founder, he's 10 years older than we are, and he had done a startup already. And so he had all the old school VCs coming to him saying, "That's a horrible deal. Why would you do YC? That's dumb, you should just go raise your Series A." So we were pumped about it, but then all these advisors were telling us, "You're idiots. Why are you doing this?" So it was really hard to work through

that and then separate the signal from the noise, because everybody obviously wants to tell you what is best for them, not what's best for you.

Jessica Livingston: The VCs, if they could catch you before Y Combinator, they'd be much happier.

David Lieb: And so I distinctly remember I had a phone call with Paul, PG, and I remember him distinctly saying the sentence, "There's no way for me to prove a priori that it's going to be totally worth it, but it will be." And I'm like, that's a difficult argument to make. It's not very convincing to me, because I don't know you. I think part of it was that we were outsiders. We were not students of PG's blog. When I heard about YC, actually, the first thing I did was I bought your book and I read *Founders at Work* just to learn about this space a little bit. In hindsight, I look back and I'm like, "Oh my gosh, we were such... We had no idea what we were doing." And you can see some of the things we did. Obviously we didn't know what we were doing.

Jessica Livingston: Wait a second. I now have a ton of questions. First, let me just interject though that I think the VCs are very shortsighted to think that startups are not better off doing Y Combinator, because I think in the long run we offer so much.

David Lieb: Well, I think now that's very proven for sure.

Jessica Livingston: Yes. What tipped the scale? What made you say, "Okay, we're going to take a chance on Y Combinator?"

David Lieb: So we talked to Savraj, and I think he was in the batch with Dropbox, if I recall correctly. And so he told us, I think he connected us with Drew and I don't know if we ever talked to Drew, but we learned about Dropbox. And I think there were enough positive signals from doing that very quick diligence, I guess you would call it, that we decided, "Okay, this sounds pretty great, and everything we've heard from all these people sounds like it's in our best interests." Compared to some of the other experiences that we had where VCs or other accelerators or whatever would come talk to us and we would leave those conversations just thinking, "Something doesn't feel right." So there was definitely this gut spidey sense that YC was probably going to be a good idea.

Jessica Livingston: Oh, thank goodness for your spidey sense, that's all I have to say. The three of you were, were you in total agreement or was Andy a little bit like, "I've been down this road, maybe I don't need it"? Or how did that work out?

David Lieb: In the end, yes, we were in total agreement. I think we were very close and very good decision makers together. But I would say Andy was the one who was getting bombarded by all these people that he knew, and they heard that he was doing his second startup. And all the people that he knew were just saying, "You're going to give up how much equity for how much money?" And of course this was back at the beginning of YC, so I think we got \$6,000 per founder, I think was the deal.

Jessica Livingston: Yes, 18 grand.

David Lieb: Yeah. I found a photo I took of a check recently. So he was just getting bombarded by all these people and he was just trying to communicate to us what he was hearing from people. And so for me, I still to this day very much look up to Andy, he was like my mentor, I guess. And when your mentor's telling you, "Everybody that now I know, who's smart, is telling me this is a dumb thing to do. Should we talk about it?" I think that was the challenge for us, and thank God that we did it.

Jessica Livingston: Yes. Let me dig in just very quickly. So you knew Andy, who was 10 years older than you from Texas Instruments, is that right?

David Lieb: Yeah. So I was working at TI, that was my first job out of grad school. And TI acquired Andy's previous startup, it was a hardware technology, it was a chip technology to build micromirror devices on a chip. And so when we acquired this company, this was the first time I'd ever seen an acquisition. And so that was also new to me. I researched, I looked up Andy on the internet, and I'm like, "Oh, he went to Princeton. So did I, I should befriend this guy maybe I can learn something from him." So as soon as they got acquired, he and I started talking and I think we were very aligned on a bunch of things we wanted to do in our lives. And we worked together a bit at TI for maybe a year or two before we both decided to leave, actually. I was going to go to business school and Andy was going to leave and eventually wanted to do another startup.

And on the last day at TI, we had lunch, actually, I remember it very distinctly. And I didn't know him super well, but we worked together a bit. And I said to him, "Hey, one day I think I might want to start a company too. Maybe we should do it together." And we both jokingly said, "Sure, later on we'll get in touch." And then I went to visit school and had the idea for Bump literally four weeks later I think. And I emailed him back, I'm like, "Hey, about that lunch where we said years from now maybe we'll do a startup. How about right now?" And so that was a funny turn of events.

Jessica Livingston: So you then went to University of Chicago to get your MBA from TI, and that's where you met the third founder, Jake. Is that right?

David Lieb: It was, yeah. So in business school, if you're an actual engineer, which both Jake and I were, they ask you, "Do you know anything about finance or accounting or any of these things?" And of course our answer was like, "No." And so they invite those people to do this. I don't know what it's actually called, but we called it remedial accounting, which is before business school starts, they ask you to come and learn the basics. So Jake and I were part of that class, and at the beginning of the class, you go around the room and say where you used to work and what your background is. And he said he worked at TI, at the Dallas Texas, location. And I'm like, "I lived a mile from where you worked. And I worked at a different location," but we didn't know each other. So afterwards we went and talked to each other and got to know each other, and we both wanted

to do stuff in tech. And so we hit it off. And then when we started working on Bump, we worked together.

Jessica Livingston: So were you working on Bump whilst going to business school?

David Lieb: Yeah. Literally the idea for Bump, business school started, and I think I wrote down on my little piece of paper the idea for Bump two weeks later. It was really at the very beginning of business school. And it's because I was facing this actual problem in my life, which was I was meeting all of my new business school classmates and we were all exchanging phone numbers and names to type into our brand new shiny iPhones. And at the time, I was naive and I thought, "Oh, why hasn't anybody solved this problem? Gosh, seems like we could solve that." And so we started working on that little side project just to make our lives easier. And then it turned into something more.

Jessica Livingston: Surprise, surprise. So many startups start like this.

David Lieb: It was totally a side project. You hear about a lot of these great startups that start as side projects. For us it was, "Oh, we could build an app. It might be fun." I had heard, actually, a story of another student at University of Chicago, he's now an engineering director at Google. Who had, in the summer when they opened up the App Store for the very first time, he wrote an app that would look for wifi networks that were open and didn't have a little firewall or whatever where you have to type in a CAPTCHA or something. And he put it on the App Store and sold it for \$4 that summer, and he made a hundred thousand dollars that summer. And so I heard that story and I was like, "Oh, I could pay for my business school expenses by making an app." So our goal at the beginning for Bump, literally I think I told my dad, I was like, "I think I can make \$25,000 doing this app, Dad. It'll be cool." And of course it was more than that later.

Jessica Livingston: So you built it, because you yourself wanted to use it, but you also thought, "Hey, I could cover a lot of the costs of being a student here by making some money from the App Store"?

David Lieb: Yeah, I thought there was a chance that maybe you could make some money on this thing. But the idea of making something that millions of people would use and love was never even on my mind. It was a total side project. So Jake and I were in school, full-time students, it was business school, we were engineers, so at least at the beginning it wasn't super hard for us. So we had a lot of extra time and Andy had just quit his job, so he had no job at the time, and we just worked on it as a side project. Every night at 9:00 PM Central Time in Chicago and 7:00 PM Pacific Time, we'd all get on, I think, Skype at the time and talk about what we would work on this week and this weekend. And every weekend we would decide, should we work on it more or are we done? And that happened every week for 30 weeks. And then we finally decided, "Okay, let's launch this. I think people are going to really want to use it."

Jessica Livingston: So when did you launch then?

David Lieb: It was the spring of 2009. So we started working on it the fall of 2008. And so part-time, it probably took us three or four months to build it, I guess. I remember we submitted it to Apple on Valentine's Day 2009, that was the moment we submitted it to the App Store. And then we heard nothing, no response, nothing for Apple for a month. And I thought, "This doesn't seem right, I see other apps getting approved quickly." And it turns out, in hindsight what had happened is we got accidentally filed into some purgatory area in the App Store review process. And this was very early in the App Store review process, so they were still figuring out all their processes.

I decided, "All right, well I got to do something about this." So I went onto all of my alumni databases. So I had gone to Princeton, but then I also did a graduate degree at Stanford and I went into all the databases and I tried to find the most senior person at Apple who went to one of my schools. And I found that Scott Forstall went to Stanford and I got his Stanford alumni email address through the system, and I just sent him an email. I'm like, "Hey Scott, I'm a student. I also went to Stanford. I submitted an app to the App Store but haven't heard anything, just wondering if you could help out." And he wrote us back and he said it's going to be resolved. And within a week our app was approved. So it's just, "Wow, these things actually work."

Jessica Livingston: So now it's spring of 2009, at the same time you're applying to YC. At some point you said, "Okay guys, we're going to drop out of school and get serious about this."

David Lieb: Yeah, that's certainly one of the paths that we thought it could take. For Jake and I also though, it was, in business school you do a summer internship before your second year, and neither of us had any interest in doing the normal summer internships that all of our classmates were doing. And so for us it was, "Oh, we can work on our startup in the summer. If it fails, we have a nice option to go back to school. And if it works, we can defer and go back to business school the next year or the year after that." So for many years we would tell the school, "Oh yeah, we're still working on it, but next year, we'll come back next year." And after some number of times of doing that, we'd realize, "Oh, that's not going to happen." But the school was really great and gracious.

Jessica Livingston: Oh my gosh, that was, by the way, the original vision for YC was that people would work on the startup in the Summer Founders program and then if it didn't work out, they could just mothball it and go back to school.

David Lieb: I just remembered, we applied to YC before we had launched, and then I remember sending you, I think you specifically, I sent an email saying, "Hey, I wanted to give you an update, we launched our app," and by then we had a million users or something. And so I think that was a big shift in the YC application process for us.

Jessica Livingston: Okay. Yes. A million users, that was pretty rare back then.

David Lieb: Very rare. Yeah, the app took off pretty much immediately. Very much surprising to us.

Carolynn Levy: Your app says that you were looking to make Bump a verb like Google.

Jessica Livingston: Let me bump you.

David Lieb: I would say we achieved that, actually, at least for some number of years, yes.

Jessica Livingston: Then you and Jake moved to the Bay Area for the summer. You participate in YC, any highlights from that summer that you remember?

David Lieb: Oh gosh, so many. All the speakers, now in hindsight I realize these were luminaries, the idea that Mark Zuckerberg would come to our dinner. Wow. So that was definitely memorable. I have personal memories of walking down Pioneer and going to, we had an office right by YC, that was our first office that we got. And so many fun moments just hanging out in the YC office, going back into the back with Trevor's robots and all these fun things.

In terms of YC itself, I would say, I was looking back through my emails and I would say we underutilized it. Honestly, in hindsight, I wish we had had more office hours. I think we had five office hours with PG the entire time. That was it. I don't think we met with anybody else really. We didn't really tap into the alumni network, even though it was already very big at the time. So in hindsight, I wish we had utilized it more. And so that's the thing that I've learned now upon joining.

Jessica Livingston: Well also, it was before Bookface was written.

David Lieb: Yeah, it was. To book office hours, I think you just emailed PG and then he would say, "Oh, I put some more on the system."

Jessica Livingston: So it wasn't really your fault, we didn't have all the systems that are in place now to let you take full advantage. Now, I do vividly remember a story where you did take advantage of the alumni network and that was the advertisement on Dancing With the Stars. Tell Carolynn that story.

David Lieb: So Apple, after not approving our app for a long time, they did approve it and they took a liking to it. I think it was a great example of the cool new things you could do with an iPhone. And people loved it and it showed developers what you could do with it. So they wanted to promote our product as a way of promoting their product. And so we got a relationship with Apple. We had actually turned out, randomly actually, that we were the billionth app downloaded on the App Store, just by chance.

If you looked at the chance of being downloaded that day, I think the probability of us getting it was actually more like one in 200. So still a very small chance, but not one in a billion. And so we got a relationship with Apple from that. They called me one morning in Chicago, they were like, "Hey, your app uses servers, right?" And I said, "Yeah." And they said, "We're going to tell the world that you were the billion app downloaded, so you might want to call your server guy." So I called Andy up and I said, "Andy, are we going to be okay?" And he said, "No, we're not going to be okay." But I didn't know what to tell Apple, I couldn't tell them, "Don't promote us." So I just told Andy, "Okay, let's do what we can and maybe it'll crash. Who knows?"

And I think we survived that first day. But then Apple took a liking to us, and so they got us to sign this piece of paper saying basically it's okay for them to use our app assets in whatever materials they want. We didn't really understand what this was. I think we actually talked to John about this, "Should we sign this? I don't know." So we signed it and then we didn't really hear anything. And then one day, I think it was in August, so it was right around demo day, actually, in August that summer. We were in the office, it was 8:00 PM and I started getting text messages on my phone instantly from friends. And they were like, "I just saw you on during Dancing with the Stars." And I'm like, "What are you talking about? What do you mean?" And they said, "You were in an Apple TV commercial during Dancing With the Stars."

And then, of course, in our office we had a dashboard on a TV and the dashboard went like this, and then just a vertical line straight up. And of course everything crashed. The system could not handle that traffic. And we were down and we were totally screwed. We didn't know anything about how to fix it. The backgrounds of the three of us are two semiconductor background people, myself and Andy, and then Jake, who is a semiconductor sales and marketing background person. So we didn't know software really. So we were very much out of our element.

So we emailed the YC founders email list. At the time, there was no software for it, but it was just an email list, like a Google group. And we emailed it and we said, "Hey everyone, we were on during Dancing with the Stars we're screwed. Our servers have crashed. Does anyone know this technology stack?" I don't even remember what it was. Some Apache thing that we had. And very quickly, Alex Polvi from Cloudkick, an alum. He was like, "Oh yeah, we're experts at that. Where is your office?" So I gave him the address to the office and they showed up within 30 minutes, and I remember it very distinctly, they came in the office and they said, "Step away from the keyboards," and so we just walked away.

Jessica Livingston: A Polvi to the rescue.

David Lieb: They got in there and fixed it.

Jessica Livingston: They really said, "Step away from the keyboards"?

David Lieb: It was so great.

Carolynn Levy: Take a seat.

David Lieb: It was like a scene out of a movie. It was so great.

Jessica Livingston: And they fixed it?

David Lieb: They fixed it.

Jessica Livingston: That is so great.

Carolynn Levy: That is great.

David Lieb: So that alone paid for our YC solution. Just that one moment probably was worth it.

Carolynn Levy: That's awesome, that's a great story.

Jessica Livingston: I love magical alumni moments where people help each other out like that.

Carolynn Levy: That must have been the first season of Dancing With the Stars, by the way, because that's a long time ago. That show's been on forever.

David Lieb: Yeah, that was a long time ago. Dancing With the Stars, that show has succeeded.

Jessica Livingston: Okay, so then what happened to Bump?

David Lieb: Well, a lot of things happened. I would say the general story is we had a ton of users. We got 150 million people to install our app. We had 10 million people who used it every month. We had one or one and a half million people who used it every single day. So we were feeling really good. All of our graphs were going up into the right. We were getting inbound unsolicited interest from Marc Andreessen for our Series B. Raised money from Sequoia, we were hot. And then a year passed and we just kept building stuff and we realized the graphs are slowing down a little bit. And we just said to ourselves, "Oh, it's because we've got all the users in the world. Of course they're slowing down, that's what happens."

And then we dug into retention a little bit more deeply and we dug into frequency of use a little more deeply. And what we realized was, "Oh, people keep using it. But they use it pretty infrequently." They keep it on their phone and they'll use it a month from now or two months from now, but they're not using it all the time. Which we thought, "Well, that's probably okay." But what we learned was if you want to have a business model where each interaction is not super valuable, then you better have a lot of interactions so that you can

monetize it in some other way where the interaction value is very low, but spread across a ton of interactions. And we were, if you made a two by two grid of those two things, frequency of interaction and value of the interaction, we were in the quadrant that you do not want to be in. Which was low frequency and low value.

So sometime in 2012, I would say, is when we really internalized that and thought, "Oh crap, we are screwed. There's no business that's going to work here." And we tried our best. We tried every single idea you could come up with for monetizing Bump. We had ads, we did upsells in the app, we had digital goods we would let you buy. And they got us to a point where we could probably have become profitable, barely if we cut our staff a bunch. But we saw no path where it would be a venture returnable type of company. It was not going to be hundreds of millions of dollars a company.

So, this is the most transformational day of my career, I would say, Jake and I decided, "All right, what would PG tell us to do?" And I remember he would say, "Go talk to your users. When you're screwed, go talk to your users. That's what you should do." So that day I emailed the top 100 users of Bump, the people who use Bump the most, I just emailed a hundred of them and I said, "Could you please talk to me today?" And I think 12 of them, or 15 of them or something wrote me back. And so we called those people all day in the conference room, Jake and I. And what we learned is they were using it to share photos with their friends and family. And that was an insight that we did not get from the data. You don't see that on any graph. The graphs that you have are all aggregate data, they don't tell you exactly what's going on.

So we heard those insights and we were like, "Huh, that seems really valuable. They're using it frequently and it's actually a problem they care about." But this product is not the right product to build for those people, they're using it despite the fact that it's built for something else. And so that led us to go build another product that was around photo sharing. It used really all the same technology that we had built at Bump, it just applied it in a slightly different way. And so we built that app, it was called Flock, and it was intended to help you automatically share photos that you take with the people that you care about in your life.

And we were very excited about this app. We used it in a beta, and we got a bunch of YC people using it. It was awesome. Everybody was using it. It was so great. And we launched it and nothing happened. No one downloaded it. We couldn't get people to use it. And so it was the opposite of the Bump effect where Bump had a network effect, a chicken and egg problem. But Bump was so physical and so novel that it actually turned that liability into a big asset, because people would go tell their friends about it, "Hey, have you seen this new cool app? You got to download it. Go download it." And it would force people to download it. For Flock, it was not cool enough and not immediate enough. And it was later where people were over telling their friends about cool apps to download. This was 2012, and so the chicken and egg killed it. There was no way it was going to grow.

Jessica Livingston: Did people continue to use Bump for the photos, even though you had built Flock? Were they still doing this off-label use with Bump?

David Lieb: Those people never got Flock, that was how bad the growth was.

Jessica Livingston: They didn't even bother. But did they keep doing the photo sharing thing with Bump?

David Lieb: Yeah, they did. They did, because it was the only solution that they heard about. The problem with Flock is, before you could use it at all, you had to go convince all your friends and family to download this photo sharing app.

Carolynn Levy: That's hard.

David Lieb: At the time, nobody wanted to download another photo sharing app, it was just beyond what people wanted to do. So we learned something very interesting from that, which was, a separate app is not going to solve this problem. You've got to be the Camera Roll app. And so we had that insight and I think over the course of a week we built and designed a new prototype, which was basically what would turn into Google Photos. And we had this thing and we were like, "This is the answer. Now we know. Boy, we spent four years doing this, now we understand the future. This is the future."

And then we realized building and launching that and storing all these photos, if it were successful, that's going to be very expensive. We better have a real business model either from the start and we got to raise a lot more money. And we had already raised \$20 million. And so we had this decision point where we were like, "Are we going to go raise more money for this? And will we be able to raise more money for this? For this totally new, unproven idea." And our answer was like, "I wouldn't put money into that startup. That seems risky."

Jessica Livingston: Did you ask any of your investors to, what'd they say?

David Lieb: We didn't, not explicitly, at least. I think by that point, all the investors had communicated to us that, "You guys have given it a good shot, either figure out a way to monetize, Bump and make it valuable somehow, or there's nothing more here." But we had a lot of conviction that that new product, that third product would really work. I remember I put a calendar event on my calendar for September 15th 2012. We launched Flock that summer, it flopped. Nobody used it. And I put a date on that calendar, and that was the date I had to decide if we were going to sell the company or keep going. That was an independent company. And I did it with enough runway, I think it was nine months before we would run out of money, just so I could figure out what to do.

And on that day, I sat down and I was like, "We're going to sell the company. That's the right path." And that kicked off a whole nother process, which was, "Go sell a massive property on the internet and see how much it's worth." And

we had no idea what it might be worth. So the first step was, is anybody going to pay for Bump? Because we had a ton of users and a ton of usage, it was bigger than so many popular apps that you'd heard of. And that was a fun exercise. The answer was, basically the people who had money didn't value the user base, and the people who value the user base didn't have any money to spend. And so that put us in a tricky spot.

Jessica Livingston: Can I just quickly point out how impressed I am by your discipline, marking a date in the calendar, this is the day I'm going to decide what to do. Not only does that imply that you were not in denial, but you were actively going to take control of a decision either way. And I think that's a very subtle thing for founders to think about, because I've seen people just keep going and they need to put a date in the calendar.

David Lieb: I would call that, I eventually did the right thing, but I should have done that a year before or two years before. And I think this is a great example of, we raised a ton of money because we could. And whenever you do that, of course every founder says, "Well, I'm very disciplined. I'm going to just put that money away. We're not going to use it. We're going to figure out our business." And no one does that. You always have new ideas and you're like, "Oh, if we just could do this new feature, then it'll work." And so we did that for an extra year or two. And I wish we had had this insight moment earlier, before we'd raised so much money and before we had spent so much time pursuing a particular path.

So this is a great example, in hindsight, now I'm like, "How did YC not push us on the business model?" And the answer, I think, was at the time, all the popular startups that were really succeeding were the Facebooks of the world, the Twitters of the world. Where they were like, "We'll figure out monetization later. It'll be some sort of ad based thing, and it'll definitely work." And so I think we saw that. We were like, "Well, what's different about us? It'll work too for us. Let's just do that." And of course, in hindsight, we realized we were in that bad quadrant of the graph and it would not work for us. So I wish we had figured that out earlier in hindsight.

Jessica Livingston: But it took you several years to figure that out.

David Lieb: Yeah.

Jessica Livingston: During YC you were still getting users. Let me just state, you were still getting users.

David Lieb: Oh yeah. Oh, for sure. Oh no, we grew crazy. At some point we were on, I think, one out of every five phones in the world.

Carolynn Levy: Wow.

Jessica Livingston: Wow.

David Lieb: Full stop. That's how big we were. But we just didn't have a business model that was going to suit the way the product was used. So people ask us, "Did you have product market fit?" And it's a weird question for me, because the answer is definitely in some ways. But it's easier to have product market fit when you have a free product that anybody can use without paying in any way.

Jessica Livingston: Yeah. Okay. So you're going around talking to potential acquirers, you're not finding a good fit for that. How did Google come into play?

David Lieb: Well, the first thing I did was I did this tour of Asia with one of our investors from Andreessen Horowitz to just figure out if any of these big companies in Asia, where we were very popular. We were, I think, number two app of all time in Japan, for example. We wanted to see if any of them would really value what we had. So I went on this whirlwind tour over there, and of course the answer was they were all very interested, but they just didn't have budgets to buy companies in the way that the Silicon Valley giants did. So we did that whole exercise and then we were back to square one. We were like, "Well, that's not going to really work."

And so we kind of narrowed it down in Silicon Valley, "Which company do we think should have this product? Where would it make sense?" And the obvious answers were Apple to replace their photos app, Google to replace their, what would eventually become their photo app. Or companies like Facebook maybe, maybe they could pivot to something like this. I think those were the top three contenders. But then we went to all of them. And basically the pitch to all these companies at that point was, "Hey, Bump is big. Maybe it's useful to you, but the real answer is this photo app is going to be the winner. I'm certain of it. Let me explain to you why I'm so certain of it. Do you want that to be yours?" That was kind of the pitch.

And we got a lot of great interest. Of course, the way it eventually played out is Apple was interested, but they did not want to pay for it. And it was this typical Apple approach. I remember calling the head of Corp Dev at Apple once they had given us an offer, and I said, "Hey, your offer is great. We'd love to come do this, but your offer is literally one half of the offer of other competitors." And the answer was, "We want you to want work at Apple. That's why it's lower. It's intentionally lower, because we want you to want to work at Apple." And I was like-

Carolynn Levy: Wow, it's like a mind game.

David Lieb: Yeah. I was like, "But my investors don't want to work at Apple, so that's not going to work."

Jessica Livingston: That's a good point.

David Lieb: So yeah, so at the end of the day, the clear DNA fit, the clear mission fit was Google. It was just very obvious to me that this is where we should build this. It would allow us to build it on both platforms and not just one of the platforms. There wouldn't be any weird pull towards social with Facebook or whatever Yahoo would've maybe pulled us towards. So that was the obvious answer. So we were feeling pretty good about it. We had recovered this crashing airplane, and we were able to get it a nice soft landing for investors and a potential big future for us to go build at the company.

And then there was a reorg at Google. So in the time between when we signed the deal and when we showed up, it was a three-week period, I think, when the lawyers were doing their thing. I got a message saying, "Hey, we did a little reorg at Google. Now all the photo work that we're doing, it's no longer in the Android group that reported up to Sundar at the time, who's now the CEO, now it's being moved over to the social team, the Google+ team. And I was like-

Jessica Livingston: Oh my God, Google+.

David Lieb: Yeah. Now in hindsight I'm like, "Oh, reorgs are a big deal, you should really investigate that before you sell your company to someone." And we showed up on day one and we reported up to a different leader. And I said to that person, and I said, "Hey, I'm here. I'm Dave from the Bump team. I got my whole team here, we're going to go make this app good to meet you. And this person was like, "No, we're not doing that. Welcome to Google+, we're building Google+." And I was just like, "Oh boy."

Jessica Livingston: Were you just crushed? You must have just been crushed.

David Lieb: I think what made it worse is that I had been using, to some extent, Google+ and I knew that it was not working, and I did not see any path by which it was going to work. And once I got inside of Google, I was able to look at the data and it was even more clear to me. They were in denial that it was going to work in any way. So that made it worse, yes. But at the same time, I don't know, I like a challenge, I guess. And so I was like, "All right, well, let's see what we can do here." That first nine month period from when we got acquired till the summer of 2014, it was basically me just fighting with people internally. It was a very difficult period, I would say.

Jessica Livingston: Now, did I read somewhere that you got fired twice?

David Lieb: Yeah. Fired is probably the wrong word. I was asked to not work on that team anymore, I was told to go home. So the backstory is, the clear direction from all of my bosses was, "We're going to go build Google+ and you're going to work on the photo part of Google+, your job is to do all these things to help people post more photos to Google+." Because that's the answer, that's how we're going to get people to use Google+. And I said, "Okay, cool. I'll do that job on Monday mornings, and then Monday afternoons through Friday, I'm going to go design

the new Google Photos, okay?" And they didn't say, "Okay," they said, "No, we're not doing that." And I said, "Okay." And then I went and did that with one designer, and we basically spent all of our time designing the new Google Photos.

And within two or three months, I think we had a great idea of what it would look like, taking what we had from Bump and rebuilding it with all this new great Google technology. And we went to the bosses and said, "Okay, hey, we've been doing our job, but here's the new thing. What do you think now?" And they were still like, "No, we're not going to do it that way. That's not the approach." And so I said, "Okay, I'm going to just keep doing that, okay?" And they were like, "No, not okay." And I said, "Okay, well, I'm going to do it with all these engineers and designers. See you." And I was told basically at some point, "No, you may not do that. In fact, you're now off the team. And so they told me to go home.

On a Monday they said, "You're done. Go home. Next week we'll figure out what other job you can do inside of Google." And for me personally, because we had been acquired, I knew that they're going to pay me my four-year retention bonuses anyway. Even if they literally fired me, there'd be some way to sue them or something, and I would get my value. So my downside was very low, and I didn't want a career at Google. It wasn't like I was going to go apply for a job at Google necessarily. So I had an ability that a lot of my peers and a lot of my teammates didn't have, which was I could just burn it to the ground. And the downside is very low for me.

So I decided, well, everyone here wants to build this product. I'm the only one who can go for it and have no personal downside, it's my duty almost to do it. And as a shareholder of Google, in hindsight, also, I think that's the right thing to do for Google. So I'm actually proud that I did it. But I was removed from the team, it was a big mess. Eventually the right decision happened, and we can get into that if it's interesting, but finally we were able to build Google Photos and it worked.

Carolynn Levy: Well, so they sent you home for insubordination for a week, and you came back, you're like, "I'm still going to do it." How did that all work out?

David Lieb: Well, so the short answer is, yeah, I was sent home. And on that day I made some phone calls, I was like, "All right, well, let's go. We're escalating the situation." So I decided, well, my turn to escalate too. So I called some people that I knew in the valley, some of whom were early investors in Google, some of whom sat on the board of directors at Google. Some were personal friends with Larry. And I basically just told them, "Hey, here's the situation. Here's the product that I think we should build. Here's what I know about how it's going internally on Google+. Take these data points, tell me, it would be great if you could go talk to Larry and make sure he's aware and has decided that this is the direction he wants to go."

And I think what happened is that those conversations happened, and I think Larry decided, "Oh, that's what's happening here? No, we shouldn't do that." And he fixed it, basically. Within a month it went from, "Oh, I have no future at Google. This is not going to work." To, "Okay, we're building Google Photos. You're a separate team now, you're not beholden to that person." That person actually is now, was gone from Google within a month of that conversation. And we reported up to my boss at Google who was very much on board with building this and was a key contributor to helping me navigate all the politics of it. And at that point, it was just us and our team, and we could go rip. That was the best time in my career, I would say, where we just built Google Photos and there was no holding us back.

Jessica Livingston: David, I feel like you were this canary in the coal mine of new, bad, boring Google. I feel like someone listening to this should take notes and say, "Let's keep the David Liebs happy," and if we can keep these people happy, who have a great product sense and are driven, then Google will flourish. Because one of the things I wanted to hopefully talk to you about today is just Google. We've all heard so much about the early days. And in fact on the series we interviewed Paul Buchheit, heard a lot about when it was back in the days of employee 23. But now later on, Google, it sounds like you were fighting this bureaucratic headwind almost the whole time until the tide change, because of Larry.

David Lieb: Yeah, definitely. I would say, if I had to summarize what I learned and how I saw Google change over the nine years I was there, I would say the number one thing was actually just personal incentives of leaders and how do they align or not align with building the right products for users, or taking risks is maybe the better way of saying it. In the early days of Google, they took a lot of risks. PB went and built a new product on the side and they let him launch it. And that was a pretty risky thing to do, but they didn't have as much to lose. There were fewer eyeballs on every single thing that they did. If they made a mistake, it was like, "Whoops, we made a mistake. Ha-ha, funny, funny." And then they could fix it.

These days, Google is a very different beast. It's under tons of regulatory pressure. Politicians are looking at everything that Google does. And the other effect that I observed is the people who progressed up the ranks at Google and became the top level leaders, the nature of those people changed. And what I mean by that is in the early days, they were pioneers and risk-takers, and they would go push and do interesting new things because their personal incentive was to make Google very successful. So doing something that might have a 10% chance of success but could have a payoff of a hundred x, they would go do. Fast-forward to today, the personal incentive of taking a risk that'll have a 90% chance of failure is not worth it for most leaders at Google. And I think that is the key thing that changed over those years.

So today, there's lots of cool great things that Google could do. In fact, right now we're having this AI moment where OpenAI is doing all these great things and launching them publicly to the world. And Google has all of the same technology

internally, I'm sure, I don't know personally, but I'm sure that all these demos, it could exist very quickly inside of Google. But Google can't launch them, because if they do and it says something stupid, it's a big problem for Google. And all this PR backlash and regulatory backlash will happen. Whereas when it happens with OpenAI, the world is like, "Oh, well, it's early days AI," they give them a pass.

Jessica Livingston: It is a bit unfair.

David Lieb: That's the biggest problem. But this is a perfect example of why startups can beat big companies, is because big companies are encumbered by all of this cruft around them.

Jessica Livingston: Well, this is what I wanted to ask you. This is what I want to get to the heart of your nine years at later stage bureaucratic Google. People now know about starting a startup. There's lots of information online, but what we don't talk about is how do you prevent your startup from declining and decaying under the weight of bureaucracy or lame managers or no product vision or whatever? What advice do you have?

David Lieb: Yeah, I wish I knew the silver bullet. I think the best way to think about it is, as you get bigger and successful you'll have all these forces that are pushing you towards being conservative, in terms of what you build, and slow and big. All these forces are going to push you there. If you want to not end up there, you need to very actively push the other way. And it is hard and it's demoralizing work, because you don't feel the success right away. But you need to ingrain that in the DNA in some way. And I would say that is the part that saddens me the most about Google, is I don't feel like that DNA of, we need to actively push hard to prevent our company from getting slow and bureaucratic. I don't feel like that's there in the places it needs to be anymore. But I think that's what you need to do as a startup. If you have a very successful startup, eventually you will become those companies unless you very actively try to prevent it.

Carolynn Levy: Nobody wants to impact the stock price is the problem. I mean, fundamentally, that's probably what that's about.

David Lieb: Yeah, I think that's exactly it. It's downside protection versus upside attacking. Attacking for upside.

Carolynn Levy: Yeah. It's interesting, Paul Buchheit, again, who we've interviewed, and he was employee number 23, he always used to tell this story to YC startups about how the incentives were just off at big companies. If you create something amazing that does super well, you get a coupon for a massage, and if you fail, you get fired.

David Lieb: That's the beautiful thing about startups. At startups, the answer is, if we succeed, everyone succeeds here and we all share in the upside. Whereas once your company gets to a certain size, and I don't know exactly when that

happens, you can no longer have that same commitment to your team. You can't tell your team, "If we succeed, we're all going to get rich." Especially once you reach the size that Google was when I joined, which was, most of Google's revenue was coming from search ads, of course, still is today. And so the thing that we were building, there was no way I could make an argument that said, "Yeah, this success of Google Photos in any near term is going to actually impact the stock price and therefore it's good for us."

So on Google Photos, literally, if I had to tell you the number of human beings on a multi hundred person team who would personally have a chance of getting rich by doing great work and really being successful on Google Photos. The answer is two, maybe three people out of multiple hundreds of people. And so that makes it difficult to incentivize that team. How do you get that team to really want to work hard and build something amazing? And the approach that I took was just, the world needs this product. You need this product. Your friends and family need this product. Let's go build it, and we will be part of history if we can pull it off. And so that was enough to motivate that early team. But now that it's successful, what do you do? It's hard. It's a much harder problem.

Carolynn Levy: I wonder if Google Photos will be the last successful thing. Google launched, not to get too dark.

David Lieb: Yeah. No, I hope not. I don't think so. I think, for all the negativity that people project onto big companies and specifically Google, there are still incredible people at Google and incredible teams doing really great work. They are just encumbered a bit more than they would be if Google was smaller and less successful. But those people are going to do great work. I think Google's challenges keep those really great people there and not have them eventually get frustrated and leave.

Carolynn Levy: That's a good segue, because you have now left and have joined on as a visiting partner at Y Combinator, which we're thrilled about. Can you tell us a little bit about what led you to this decision?

David Lieb: Yeah, it was maybe a non-standard set of circumstances that finally led me to leave Google. For year people would tell me, "Hey, you should leave Google. When are you going to do another startup? When are you going to go join some other thing?" And my honest answer to them was, "I don't feel like I'm done on Google Photos yet. I got more stuff I want to do." I really wanted to leave it when it was in a really good state as a business. After having my experience at Bump where I built something really popular but did not have any business model that would work and have it be like a longstanding thing, I really wanted that to be the case before I would leave. And so we did a bunch of work in 2020 to set Google Photos up for success there, and it worked. Now, I can't tell you the details, but it's very much working as a business and I can feel very confident that it's going to succeed for a very long time.

And then I got cancer. So in 2021 in March, totally out of the blue, randomly I found out on a Thursday that, "Hey, you need to go to the ER if something's wrong with your blood." So I go to the ER, it turns out I had leukemia. I was in the hospital for 38 days, I did chemo for all of 2021. And so I emailed my team on that Thursday, I was like, "Hey guys, I got to go to the hospital. I don't know how long this is going to be. Just take care of things, please." And then on Saturday I found out it was leukemia and I found out it would be like a yearlong battle where I would not be able to work. And so I emailed them again on Saturday, I was like, "Hey, turns out it's going to be a year. See you next year". And that was it and now it's gone.

And so the team did a fantastic job without me. And so when I finally got healthy and came back, I came back and I was like, "Oh, wow, they're doing great. They don't need me per se. Maybe I can add some value, but they don't need me to operate." And I think at that moment, two things occurred to me. One was that, they don't actually need me, it's going okay. The business is working, the product is working. Everything's in a pretty good state. So if I was ever going to leave, I could, and I would never have had that learning had I not been forced to leave. I would never have realized that. And the second thing I realized is, life is really short. And I think for my entire life, I never really internalized what that meant until I thought I was going to die on the Thursday night. That first Thursday night in the ER, I thought there was a 50% chance I would die. And that was pretty real for me.

Carolynn Levy:

A 50% chance. Oh my God, that's frightening.

David Lieb:

It wasn't actually. It turns out there was no chance I was going to die that night. But in my brain, in my head, given the information I had, I was like, "Oh crap. If I fall asleep, I might not wake up." And so I tried to not fall asleep that night. That was my solution. Didn't work. But when I got through that experience and it was a pretty grueling experience for everybody involved, I realized, wow, I made it 40 years being perfectly healthy. And now I've almost died. And best case scenario, I've got 50, 60 more years left. Best case, nobody lives meaningfully past a hundred. And so I thought, "Oh wow, I now have as much time left as I've ever had, and it could end any time. So what do I want to spend my time doing?"

And the advice I would always give people who asked me career advice was always flippant but true, which is find things that you're interested in and find ways to do that more each day. And if you're ever going the opposite of that, you should check yourself and go back towards stuff that you really enjoy doing.

And so when I first came back to Google, I would block some time on my calendar in the morning to talk to startups. Startups I was investing in or YC alums or whatever. And then I would go do my job at Google and I asked myself this question, "What did I enjoy most today?" And the answer for so many days in a row was, oh, I liked that block in the morning when I was able to talk to that founder or help that company or give them this product advice. And I finally decided, all right, you should really do what you tell people.

And so the answer was like, all right, I should leave. It's hard to leave, you're giving up a lot of money to leave and prestige and all these other things. But I decided, well, if I die in 10 years, I don't want to have not done what I really want to do and what I love to do, which is work with startups. So it was very obvious I should do that. And then within a day of thinking through the ways I could go do that, it was very obvious, "Oh, I should go to YC, that's of course the place I should go." So here I am.

Jessica Livingston: I know, we're so excited. Can I ask you, do you think that your stubbornness and determination played a role in getting you through that yearlong battle with chemo and getting over the cancer?

David Lieb: Oh, yeah. Oh, absolutely. When you ask people their biggest strengths and their biggest weaknesses, I would say almost always they're the same thing. And so for me, it is this determination, stubbornness, whatever you want to call it. If you ask my wife what she is annoyed about most about me, it's that of course, but also it's in many cases a superpower that I've got. And it helped me with Google Photos, I was able to just plow forward and say, "Well, I'm not going to take no for an answer, so we're just going to keep doing this until I'm literally gone from this in some way." And with the cancer, it was like, "Well, this is a difficult hand to be dealt, but I'm still way more fortunate than most people in the world. So I had better go beat this. If I don't, my God, I'm passing up this incredible hand I was dealt in life even though this last round was not so great." So I just put my head down and said like, "All right, just going to go do it."

And I think one of the learnings for anyone who deals with this, the job of a cancer patient is survive. That's all you have to really do. You're allowed to let go of all your other responsibilities in life when you get dealt that hand. What's harder is all the other people in your life, usually it's your spouse or your partner or your close family members, they have to take on a bunch of that duty and do things that you were doing before. But also they have to be a cancer patient partner, which is a full-time job almost. So I would say it was way harder for my wife. And we had a five-month-old kid at the time, now she's two. Yeah, it was hard, I would say, but we made it through.

Jessica Livingston: Oh, well, we're so glad that you're better and you're in remission, and I couldn't be happier. And we're so happy to have you back at YC, you've just finished your first batch, right? Or no, no.

David Lieb: No, I finished-

Jessica Livingston: No, you're starting.

David Lieb: We're going into my first batch, yeah. Just finished most of the interviews for the first batch.

Jessica Livingston: See, it feels like you've been there for a longer, David. You're going into your first batch that will be in January, and this will air soon after, I hope. How does it feel to be back on the other side reviewing applications?

David Lieb: It's fantastic. I've learned, I tell people in the, I guess I've been here three months now. In the three months I've been at YC, I feel like I can honestly say I've learned more than the previous three years at Google. I just see so many things that I would've never seen before. I've learned so much about the world, and I'm surrounded by all the rest of the people at YC, and they're just fantastic people. And it is just a clear different world than the world I was in before. So I'm very excited about it.

Jessica Livingston: I remember you're actually in this magical place timing wise, where you've interviewed people, they've accepted they're heading to Y Combinator, but they haven't started. You haven't seen the ones that are going to blatantly fail and not try that hard yet. You're not disillusioned with some of them. You're optimistic about all of them. You know what I'm talking about, C Levy.

Carolynn Levy: Oh yeah, I do.

Jessica Livingston: Well, we're very excited. Do you think you have another startup in you?

David Lieb: It's a great question. Maybe, there are certain people who maybe join YC as visiting partners and say, "I just need a little break, and then I want to do it again," or, "I want to go be successful." For me, that chip on the shoulder, maybe as it were, I don't feel like I have it. I think I knocked that chip off my shoulder with Google Photos, so I don't need to do it. And at least right now in my life, I don't know if I could responsibly say, "I'm going to go raise money and be successful at a startup," just because it takes a lot out of you, as you both know. Maybe one day if the right problem presents itself and gets me hooked on it, maybe.

But I'm having a blast helping founders and now having been a father, I'm about to have a second kid. You definitely feel this idea of, "Well, I don't have to be the person in the arena necessarily, but I can help these other people who are the future of the world. I can help them in a way that people before me helped me." And that's a very satisfying feeling. And I don't know if I really internalized it until I had kids myself. And you just feel so good helping those people be successful.

Jessica Livingston: Right. And you want to spend time with your kids, especially when they're little.

David Lieb: Oh, that too. That too. COVID has been really great for that, to be honest, for my entire daughter's life I'm around, which is really great.

Carolynn Levy: That is great.

Jessica Livingston: And dare I say, startups are slightly incompatible with that.

David Lieb: Yes.

Jessica Livingston: Sorry. I'm in such a dark mood today. You're such a cheerful, cheerful, optimistic guest and I'm like negative over here.

David Lieb: Well Carolynn, when you were talking about Google, I think the other thing that maybe worked well for us is the demographics. The people at Bump generally were reasonably young and early in our careers. And so when we joined Google, we could grow up there. And now we're all having kids. And the idea of going and working in a different modality at a startup is not maybe what you want to do at that point in your life. So that's another force that gets people to stay on their path, whatever path they've chosen.

Jessica Livingston: Yeah. Well, the YC community of founders is super lucky to have you, and I encourage all of them to reach out and book office hours with you.

David Lieb: Yeah, please do.

Carolynn Levy: You're about to get inundated.

Jessica Livingston: It's been so much fun catching up with you. I'm so happy to see your face again, because I loved working with you way back when, it seems like ages ago.

Carolynn Levy: Was ages ago.

Jessica Livingston: Heck, it was. It was very olden days of YC, so we're so happy to have you back and great to see you.

David Lieb: Yeah, thank you.

Carolynn Levy: It was great to hear the whole story. I'm glad I know it now. Can we ask about the resignation letter? Is that?

Jessica Livingston: Oh my God, the resignation letter, I couldn't ask about that-

David Lieb: Wait, from Google you mean?

Jessica Livingston: Yes. I'm obsessed with the resignation letter, unfortunately that you told me about. Do you remember, you told me that you wrote the internal resignation letter and you had to submit it for-

Carolynn Levy: Approval.

David Lieb: My goodbye letter to the team, yes. I wrote an email to say that I was leaving to send to the whole Google Photos team. And I needed to have it reviewed by various parties internally to make sure it was appropriate. And I think that if you looked at what the word changes were, 50% of the words were altered,

compared... In that same week I wrote the tweet thread telling people that I was going to join YC and at the same time I submitted my goodbye email to the Google bureaucracy and I submitted my hello statement to the YC PR team. And the difference was just so dramatic. It was, "50% of your words need to be changed. Here are the new sentences that are approved," and the YC response was, "Looks good. Let me know when you tweet it and I'll retweet it."

Carolynn Levy: It's so sad.

David Lieb: Two different worlds.

Jessica Livingston: But didn't they make you take out, you ended, "Just as a parting thought, I encourage you to keep innovating, keep shipping." And they're like, "Take that out, it'll make people feel badly."

David Lieb: It was long, and that was the deemed the lowest value piece of the email, I suppose.

Carolynn Levy: You're so diplomatic.

David Lieb: Well, I get it. When people would leave the photos team that I wasn't happy leaving, the people that I wished would stay, they would generally send a goodbye email. And when they would say critical things, I would always ask them, "Hey, can you send me your email before you send it to the whole team?" Because I want you to be able to say goodbye, but also I want to control the message because that's my team, I want to make it good. So I get it. Of course, we all do these things.

I think for me, what I've always tried to do and tried to do going forward is just always make sure that you're being authentic in what you say and do. And don't ever let the position you're in or the role you've got or whatever, change how you present yourself. Because once you do that, then people get, they see it immediately. They're like, "Yeah, it seems like corp speak. I wonder what she really thinks." And once that happens, you lose the trust of the team, I think. So that's the one thing I always tried to do. And it probably was career limiting to me at Google in some ways, because they couldn't, like if I were an SVP at Google, for example, I think there'd be probably lots of employees complaining about things that I would say or do. But that's just me, take it or leave it.

Jessica Livingston: Well, David, thank you for your time.

David Lieb: Yeah. It's an honor being on this. Wow.

Jessica Livingston: Thank you.

Carolynn Levy: Bye David.

David Lieb: Good seeing you, bye-bye.

Jessica Livingston: Bye, David.

Carolynn Levy: Thanks.

Jessica Livingston: Well, that was fun, huh, Carolynn?

Carolynn Levy: He's so cheerful. He's great, actually. I really, really love the story about, "You can't do this." "I'm just going to do it." "You can't do it." "I'm just going to do it. I'm doing it anyway." That is incredibly appealing to me as a person. Just that personality, "I'm just going to do it."

Jessica Livingston: I know, that he was so sure of what the right decision was, and he just refused to listen to people who were trying to prevent it. It's so fascinating. That is the mindset of a startup founder.

Carolynn Levy: And I think too, he was very clear that he's like, "I didn't have a lot of downside. I didn't have a lot to lose." I think the superpower people are the people who can also be like, "I have a lot to lose, but this is who I am and this is the way I'm going to handle this situation. Consequences be damned." And I like that.

Jessica Livingston: He was there for nine years, you have to agree with me that of most of the startups that we know that get acquired by bigger companies, they don't last nine years.

Carolynn Levy: Oh my God. No way. How long did PG last at Yahoo?

Jessica Livingston: One year to the day. And by the way, he will tell you this, he left a lot of money on the table, because he was getting new options or something every single month. And that was back in 1999, I guess, when the stock price was still doing okay. But one year to the day he quit.

Carolynn Levy: Well, and that's, even the show, Silicon Valley joked about the rest invest and all that stuff. So founders don't stay at these big companies. The fact that he stayed for nine years is a very unusual fact.

Jessica Livingston: I love his commitment. He wanted to just make sure that Google Photos was a huge success and was in good hands and was working properly. I love that.

Carolynn Levy: Yeah. I love it too. That is amazing.

Jessica Livingston: And I'm so happy that he's in remission and healthy again.

Carolynn Levy: Yeah, so scary.

Jessica Livingston: That was really scary to hear about. And I'm so glad he is at YC. I love when people who went through the program come back.

Carolynn Levy: They have all these interesting then and now observations, which I think are really powerful. And that's all good.

Jessica Livingston: Well, you've been through so much by the time you've done a startup and then sold it and worked somewhere else. You have so much more data in your head that you can use to advise young, naive people like yourself, you 10 years ago or whatever.

Carolynn Levy: And also just coming to the job having figured out, this is what makes me happy. I'm so glad you're here, because that's exactly the kind of people you want to work with.

Jessica Livingston: And now I'm no longer in a dark mood. I'm so happy and optimistic that's how I'm going to look at the rest of the week.

Carolynn Levy: Well, and I think it's also happy hour for you right now. So there's that.

Jessica Livingston: It is. It's a little after six. I'm going to go check in on the kids, and this was really fun, C Levy. So I'll see you next time.

Carolynn Levy: Yes, usual. All right. See you next time.

Jessica Livingston: Okay. Bye.

Carolynn Levy: Bye.